

FDA Public-Hearing Dockets

Comment Volume Analysis (2008–Present)

This report analyzes public comment volumes on **584** FDA dockets identified via the regulations.gov API as containing notices mentioning “public hearing.” Data was collected from the `/v4/documents` and `/v4/comments` endpoints, with comments counted per document using `meta.totalElements`.

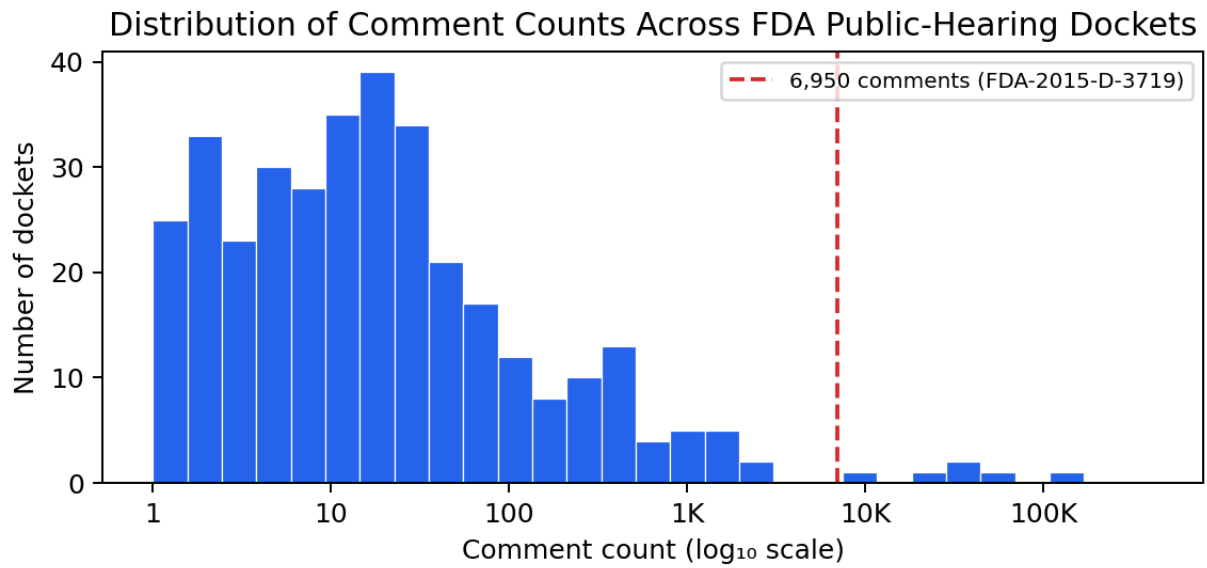
Of the 584 dockets, **523** were flagged as potential false positives (their notice titles did not contain keywords like “public hearing” or “hearing; request for comments”). Statistics are presented both with and without these flagged dockets.

Summary Statistics

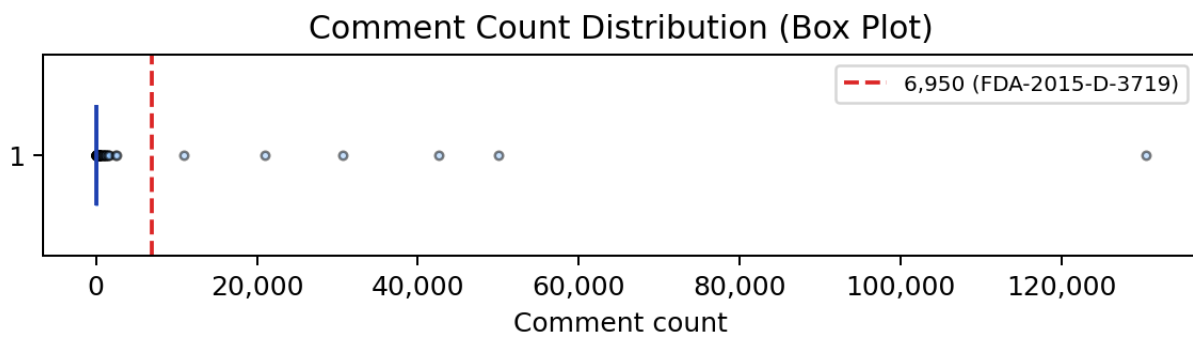
Metric	All Dockets (n=584)	Confirmed Hearings (n=61)
Mean	549.1	178.8
Median	2.5	25
75th percentile	20.0	85
90th percentile	109.0	385
95th percentile	384.7	1,222
99th percentile	3,925.6	1,841.6
6,950 → percentile rank	99.0%	100.0%

6,950 comments (docket FDA-2015-D-3719) falls at the 99th percentile across all dockets and at the 100th percentile among confirmed hearing dockets.

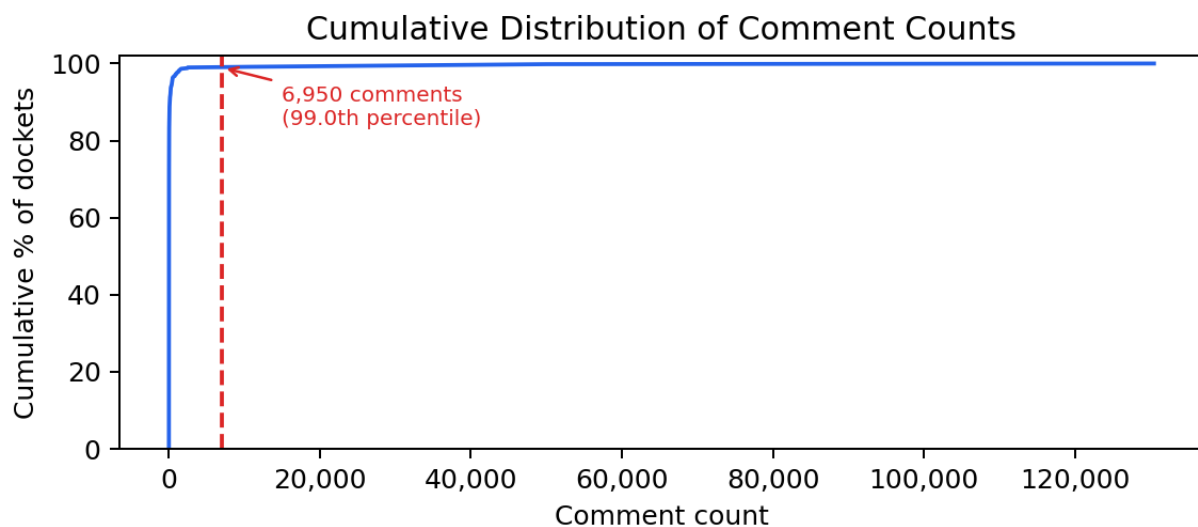
Comment Distribution



The distribution is extremely right-skewed. Most dockets receive fewer than 100 comments, while a handful of vaccine-advisory-committee dockets drive comment volumes into the tens or hundreds of thousands.

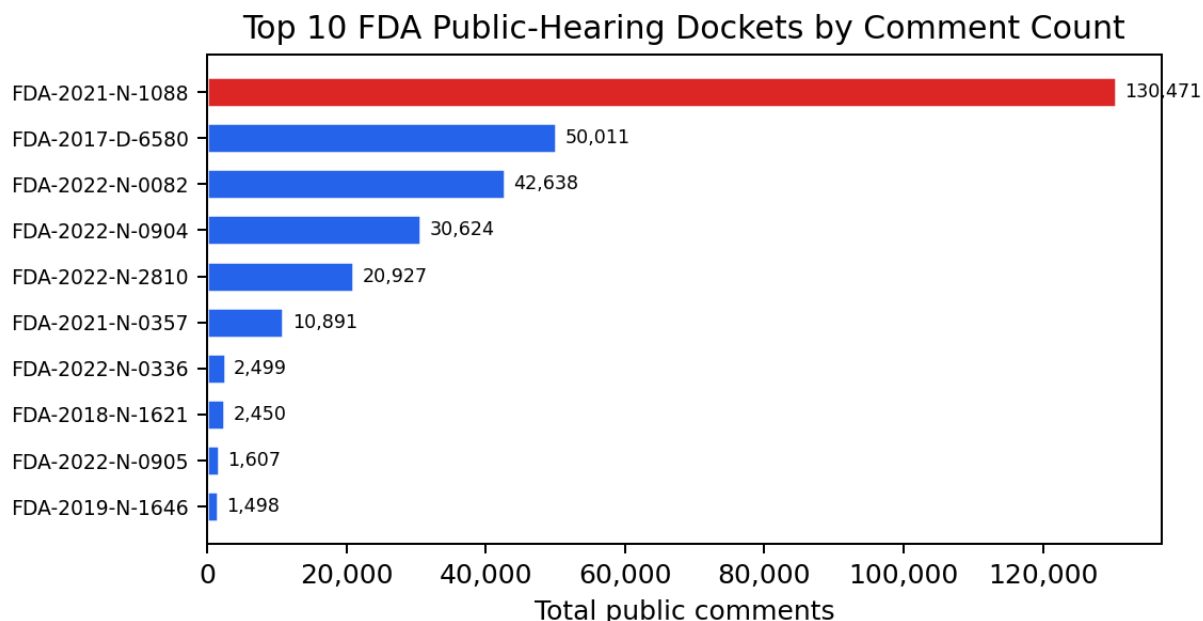


Cumulative Distribution



The CDF shows that ~99% of dockets receive fewer than 6,950 comments. The steep rise at the left indicates most dockets cluster near zero.

Top 10 Dockets by Comment Count



Rank	Docket ID	Title	Comments
1	FDA-2021-N-1088	Vaccines and Related Biological Products Advisory Commi...	130,471
2	FDA-2017-D-6580	Drug Products Labeled as Homeopathic	50,011
3	FDA-2022-N-0082	Vaccines and Related Biological Products Advisory Commi...	42,638
4	FDA-2022-N-0904	Vaccines and Related Biological Products Advisory Commi...	30,624
5	FDA-2022-N-2810	Vaccines and Related Biological Products Advisory Commi...	20,927
6	FDA-2021-N-0357	Pharmacy Compounding Advisory Committee; Notice of Meet...	10,891
7	FDA-2022-N-0336	Vaccines and Related Biological Products Advisory Commi...	2,499
8	FDA-2018-N-1621	Patient-Focused Drug Development on Chronic Pain; Publi...	2,450
9	FDA-2022-N-0905	Vaccines and Related Biological Products Advisory Commi...	1,607
10	FDA-2019-N-1646	Joint Meeting of the Drug Safety and Risk Management Ad...	1,498

Five of the top 10 dockets are Vaccines and Related Biological Products Advisory Committee (VRBPAC) meetings, reflecting the high volume of public engagement with FDA vaccine decisions during and after the COVID-19 pandemic.

False-Positive Flagging

Of 584 dockets, **523** (90%) were flagged as potential false positives because their hearing-notice titles did not contain any of the following keywords: “public hearing,” “hearing; request for comments,” “request for comments; hearing,” “notice of hearing,” or “public meeting.”

These documents appeared in the search results because they mention “public hearing” somewhere in their text but may not be actual hearing notices. The **61 confirmed hearing dockets** show a higher median comment count (25 vs. 2.5), suggesting that actual hearing dockets attract more engagement than the false positives.

Methodology

Step 1 — Docket Discovery: Queried

`/v4/documents?filter[agencyId]=FDA&filter[documentType]=Notice&filter[searchTerm]=public+hearing` (and variant `public+hearing+request+for+comments`), with `filter[postedDate][ge]=2008-01-01`. Extracted unique parent `docketId` from each result and deduplicated across both searches.

Step 2 — Comment Counting: For each docket, fetched all documents via `/v4/documents?filter[docketId]={id}`.

For each document with an active comment period (`openForComment` or `commentEndDate`), queried

`/v4/comments?filter[commentOnId]={objectId}&page[size]=5` and read `meta.totalElements`. Summed across all documents per docket.

Rate Limiting: The `regulations.gov` API allows 1,000 requests/hour. The script enforces a 3.7-second minimum interval between requests (~970/hr) and retries on HTTP 429 with exponential backoff capped at 20 minutes. All progress is persisted to SQLite for resumability.

Note on FDA-2015-D-3719: This docket (Draft Guidances Relating to the Regulation of Human Cells, Tissues, and Cellular and Tissue-Based Products) is a Draft Guidance, not a Notice, and did not appear in the search results. Its 6,950 comments are used as a benchmark for percentile ranking against the hearing dockets found.